

Leopard

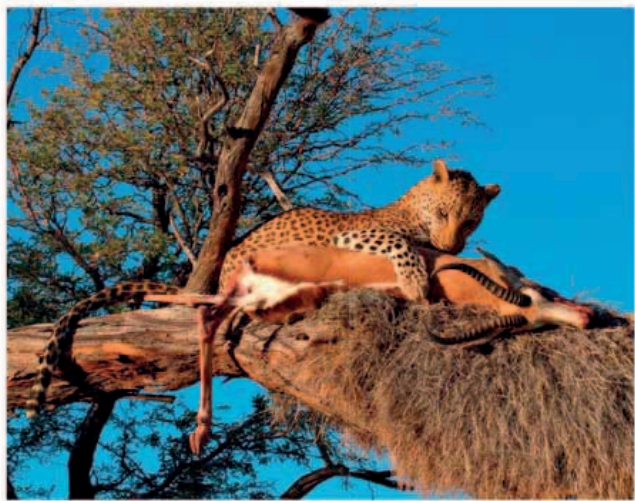
Panthera pardus

One of the smallest and strongest climbers of the big cats, leopards are famed for their spots or “rosettes,” but not all have the same type. Some are solid, others have light patches in the center, but all spots camouflage this hunter in habitats ranging from rainforest to desert, from Africa to the Himalayas.

Night hunter

Solitary except during the mating season, leopards are mainly nocturnal. Like all cats, they have a membrane called the tapetum lucidum at the back of their eyes that reflects twice as much light through their retinas, giving them superb night vision. They eat fish, birds, reptiles, hooved mammals such as antelope as well as wild pigs and baboons, and carrion. Long-bodied and powerfully built, leopards hunt by stealth, pouncing on their prey and quickly suffocating it. They can pull 275 lb (125 kg) giraffe carcasses up into trees.

Each leopard has a home territory, and its boundaries overlap with those of nearby leopards. Females give birth to two or three smoky-gray cubs, keeping them in a variety of den sites to protect them from predators. By the age of six to eight weeks, cubs regularly leave their den site and begin to eat solid food. They remain with their mother for the first two years of their lives.



△ AT EASE

Leopards are very comfortable in trees, often hauling their kills into branches to keep them safe from lions and scavengers such as hyenas.

▷ OPEN WIDE

The leopard's long canines are used for stabbing and gripping. The rough tongue is used to lick scraps of meat from bones and for grooming.

Leopards can catch prey up to **10 times** their own weight

- ↔ 3–6 ft (0.9–1.9 m)
- ⚖ 82–200 lb (37–90 kg)
- ⊗ Near threatened
- 🍖 Deer, baboons, fish, birds
- 🏠



Africa, S. Asia

